

Knowledge, skills and understanding

The *General Certificate in Secondary Education* is part of the Level 1 and 2 provision. This specification is based on the GCSE Subject Criteria for Psychology which are prescribed by the regulatory authorities and are mandatory for all awarding bodies.

Subject content

The content of GCSE specifications in psychology must reflect the learning outcomes.

All specifications should include a rationale that clearly reflects the approach taken within the specification. This approach should include an emphasis on one or more of the following:

- the implications of psychology for society
- explaining, theorising and modelling in psychology
- procedural knowledge of ethical practice in psychology.

Aims and learning outcomes

GCSE specifications in psychology must encourage students to be inspired, moved and changed by following a broad, coherent, satisfying and worthwhile course of study and to gain an insight into related sectors, such as science. They should encourage students to develop a personal interest and enthusiasm for psychology and prepare them to make informed decisions about further learning opportunities and career choices.

This GCSE specification in psychology enables students to:

- engage in the process of psychological enquiry to develop as effective and independent students, and as critical and reflective thinkers with enquiring minds
- develop an awareness of why psychology matters
- acquire knowledge and understanding of how psychology works and its essential role in society
- develop an understanding of the relationship between psychology and social, cultural, scientific and contemporary issues, and its impact on everyday life
- develop an understanding of ethical issues in psychology
- develop an understanding of the contribution of psychology to individual, social and cultural diversity
- develop a critical approach to scientific evidence and methods.

Develop knowledge, understanding and skills

This Edexcel GCSE specification requires students to develop knowledge, understanding and skills in the following contexts:

- Core areas of psychology: biological, social, cognitive, developmental and individual differences.
- Application of psychology: the use of psychology to explain and influence everyday behaviour and experience, within appropriate, relevant, contemporary contexts.

Demonstrate knowledge, understanding and skills

This Edexcel GCSE specification requires students to demonstrate knowledge, understanding and skills in the following areas:

Data, theories and explanations:

- collection of data from secondary sources, including the consideration of validity and reliability of evidence
- analysis and evaluation of qualitative and quantitative data
- interpretation of data to provide evidence for testing ideas and developing theories
- explanations of behaviour by developing and using scientific theories and models.

Investigation and enquiry:

- planning to conduct a psychological investigation and structure a hypothesis
- evaluating design and ethical implications of psychological enquiry.

Evaluative and interpretative skills:

- recalling, analysing, interpreting, applying and questioning information or ideas
- presenting information, developing arguments and drawing conclusions, using psychological concepts, terminology and conventions.

Applications and implications of psychology:

- the use of contemporary psychological developments and their benefits and drawbacks
- how psychological knowledge and ideas change over time
- appreciation of the implications of culture in psychological enquiry
- relationship of psychological study to other areas of scientific enquiry and society as a whole.

List of unit contents

Content is divided into two units. The units are divided into topic areas. The key questions in the topics focus on the process of psychology in context.

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Unit 1 Perception and Dreaming

Content overview

Topic A: How do we see our world?

This topic focuses on perception and illusions, drawing on biological and cognitive psychology.

Topic B: Is dreaming meaningful?

This topic addresses Freud's dream theory and the theory of activation synthesis.

Assessment overview

- Assessed through an external examination.
- The paper consists of multiple-choice and short-answer questions, and lasts 1 hour and 15 minutes.
- There are 60 marks in the examination and the result contributes 40% of the total grade for the full GCSE.